Module 4 · Workbook answers

How to achieve change

Video: 54 min **Answer sheet**

Knowing your values, your identity and your goal is not enough: this module shows how real, lasting change actually happens. You will learn why knowledge alone does not transform us, how to "install" good qualities and "uninstall" bad ones through 30 days of steady practice, and the two simple habits to start with this week.

Answer sheet: the answers are in red. The reflection questions are personal, so your own answers will be in your own words and from your own life. These model answers show what the session teaches, to guide and check your thinking.

Key teachings

1 **Where we are so far**

Module 1: the best values are those that reflect the attributes of the Creator. Module 2: you are your spirit, carrying four trusts (the body, the mind, the heart and the soul, or nafs, the seat of your emotions and desires) that you will one day hand back. Module 3: our goal is to become a friend of Allah, leading with love. This world reveals what is inside you: the word used in Surah Al-Mulk for testing (liyabluwakum) carries the sense of showing what you are made of. To get there we first close the "open windows" (cease), then turn up the heating (increase).

2 **Pieces of the jigsaw, not the whole picture**

People try many routes to change. Some change their environment: putting junk food out of sight really does help, because simply seeing it triggers the pull of reward. But moving to another country often just masks the problem and brings new temptations. Correct belief in one God is essential, yet it does not end the story: the Prophet ﷺ described a Qur'an reciter on the Day of Judgement who read so that people would call him a reciter, not for Allah. Knowledge alone is not the answer either: Iblis had great knowledge and it did not save him, and if knowing Arabic transformed people, every Arab would be perfect. Each of these is a piece of the jigsaw. Group members added more pieces: building a real yearning for change, honest self-analysis with clear, specific actions, and taking small steps rather than everything at once.

3 **Download, then install**

We have a conscious mind, like a library holding everything we have learned from books, classes and lectures, and a subconscious mind that drives our behaviour automatically, without us noticing. Learning is like downloading an app: it does nothing until you install it. Most of us already know what we should do; we just have not installed it, so it has not become part of us. There is a second problem too: bad habits already installed in the subconscious block the good ones from going in. So we must uninstall the bad and install the good.

4 **Resistance training for the soul**

To build muscle you start with the lightest weight you can push in a controlled way, and as your body adapts you take a heavier one, until you lift what you never could before. Change works the same way: a habit is uninstalled or installed through about 30 days of repetition. Muslims already do this every year in Ramadan, a month of training to install good behaviour and remove bad, and the Prophet ﷺ taught that if a fasting person does not leave false speech and bad actions, Allah has no need of their giving up food and drink.

5 **How the 30 days work**

To uninstall cursing, stop for one day, and you suddenly notice how often you do it. Keep going day after day, building the muscle. Then on day seven an argument comes and you slip: "bad language detected", so you start again, but stronger this time, until you reach 30 days and the change is complete. Installing a good quality such as generosity works the same way: give each day through money, help, a kind word or a smile (smiling is charity), and if you miss a day, restart. In the course this is tracked on sheets, a tick for each day: one attempt may fail on day nine, the next on day 18, and the third goes all the way.

6 **All four trusts can be enlightened**

The same training applies to each trust. The body: the tongue, eyes, ears, stomach, hands and feet. The mind: replace negative and suspicious thinking, planning sins and heedlessness with mindfulness, reflection on creation, positive thinking and planning good deeds. If you have a bad opinion of your brother or sister, the problem may be your thoughts, not them: it is told that when a man's son pointed out that everyone else was asleep while they prayed at night, his father warned that thinking badly of them might wipe out the reward of his prayer. The heart: replace pride, jealousy, anger and arrogance with patience, compassion, generosity and forgiveness. Sincerity means acting because Allah told you to, not because you feel like it. The soul: its needs are met through connection with Allah, until it is full of humility, sincerity and gratitude for whatever He gives.

7 **Start with two things**

Feeling overwhelmed? The Prophet ﷺ told Abu Dharr of two qualities that are light to carry and heavy on the scales: good character and long periods of silence. Silence builds your relationship with your Creator: simply remember that Allah is with you, sees you and hears you, as He told Musa and Harun. A practical way is a silent, vibrating alarm every hour; when it goes, pause and talk to Allah about what you are doing ("this spreadsheet is impossible, make it easy for me, You are Ar-Razzaq, the Provider"). Good character builds your relationship with people: leave everyone you meet in a better state than you found them, through appreciation, patience, or letting a driver out in traffic. For this first sheet you do not restart if you miss a day; just keep going for 30 days.

8 **One at a time, and never give up**

Trying to change everything at once is where many of us have got stuck; like the open windows, close one first. After this sheet most people begin with the tongue, as the Prophet ﷺ promised Paradise to whoever guards what is between their lips and their legs, though a mentor may adjust the plan, for example stopping just one thing such as lying. You will slip, and that is expected. Adam forgot, then turned back to Allah, while Iblis's mistake was refusing to admit he was wrong. Shaytan wants you to say "I'm hopeless", yet despairing of Allah's mercy is itself a major sin. Tawbah (repentance) simply means turning back. Even the intention to do good is rewarded, so set your aspirations high: to achieve what you have never achieved, you must do what you have never done.

From the Qur'an, the Sunnah and the scholars

ٱلَّذِى خَلَقَ ٱلْمَوْتَ وَٱلْحَيَوٰةَ لِيَبْلُوَكُمْ أَيُّكُمْ أَحْسَنُ عَمَلًا ۚ وَهُوَ ٱلْعَزِيزُ ٱلْغَفُورُ

[He] who created death and life to test you [as to] which of you is best in deed - and He is the Exalted in Might, the Forgiving -

Surah Al-Mulk 67:2

قَالَ لَا تَخَافَآ ۖ إِنَّنِى مَعَكُمَآ أَسْمَعُ وَأَرَىٰ

[Allāh] said, "Fear not. Indeed, I am with you both; I hear and I see."

Surah Ta-Ha 20:46

وَٱذْكُر رَّبَّكَ فِى نَفْسِكَ تَضَرُّعًا وَخِيفَةً وَدُونَ ٱلْجَهْرِ مِنَ ٱلْقَوْلِ بِٱلْغُدُوِّ وَٱلْـَٔاصَالِ وَلَا تَكُن مِّنَ ٱلْغَـٰفِلِينَ

And remember your Lord within yourself in humility and in fear without being apparent in speech - in the mornings and the evenings. And do not be among the heedless.

Surah Al-A'raf 7:205

> *O Abu Dharr, shall I not tell you of two qualities that are light on the back and heavier on the scales than others? Hold to good character and long silence. By the One in whose hand is the soul of Muhammad, creation has done no deed like these two.*
>
> **Shu'ab al-Iman lil-Bayhaqi 4591**

> *Whoever does not give up false speech and acting upon it, Allah has no need of his giving up his food and drink.*
>
> **Sahih al-Bukhari**

> *Whoever guarantees me what is between his jaws and what is between his legs, I guarantee him Paradise.*
>
> **Sahih al-Bukhari**

Practical exercises

What have I downloaded but not installed?

1. List three things you already know you should do (or stop doing) but have not yet made part of you.
2. For each, note which piece of the jigsaw you have relied on so far: belief, knowledge, a change of place, or something else.
3. Write one bad habit that may be blocking each good one from being installed.
4. Circle the one you most want to work on after this first 30 days.

Set up your hourly reminder of Allah

1. Open the alarm app on your phone and set a silent, vibrating alarm for every hour of your day (for example 8am, 9am, 10am).
2. When it vibrates, pause for a moment of silence and remember: Allah is with me, He sees me and He hears me.
3. Talk to Allah about whatever you are doing right then, and ask Him to make it easy.
4. At the end of the day, write down one moment when the reminder changed how you felt or acted.

Leave them better than you found them

1. Write the names of the people you meet most often (your spouse, children, parents, colleagues, neighbours).
2. Next to each, write one simple way to leave them better off, such as thanking them for something you take for granted.
3. Pick the person who is hardest for you, and plan one moment of patience where you would usually react.
4. Each evening, note who you left in a better state today and how.

My first week of the 30-day sheet

Tick each day you practise.

	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Hourly reminders: Allah sees and hears me							
Moments of silence and talking to Allah							
Left everyone better than I found them							
Missed a day? Kept going, no restart							

Reflection questions and answers

1. Which piece of the jigsaw (a new place, correct belief, more knowledge) have you relied on most to change, and what did it leave out?

> The session names several pieces of the jigsaw: changing your environment (it helps, as with putting junk food out of sight, but moving country often just masks the problem), correct belief (essential, but not the whole story) and knowledge (Iblis had great knowledge and it did not save him). Group members added a real yearning for change, honest self-analysis with specific actions, and small steps. For example: "Knowledge. I attend lots of classes, but what was missing was practising one small thing day after day."

2. What do you already know well but have never really installed in your life?

> Learning is like downloading an app: it does nothing until you install it in the subconscious mind, which drives our behaviour automatically. Most of us already know what we should do; we just have not installed it, so it has not become part of us. For example: "I know I should stay quiet when I am angry. I have heard it many times, but I still snap at my children, so it has never been installed."

3. Which bad habit might be blocking a good quality from settling in your heart?

> Bad habits already installed in the subconscious block the good ones from going in, so we must uninstall the bad and install the good. The session pairs them, such as pride, jealousy, anger and arrogance in the heart against patience, compassion, generosity and forgiveness, or suspicious thinking in the mind against positive thinking. For example: "My anger may be blocking patience. I cannot become patient while I still let myself shout whenever I am tired."

4. Think of something hard you achieved before, at school or work. What does that tell you about your ability to change now?

> Change works like resistance training: you start with the lightest weight you can push in a controlled way, and as you adapt you take a heavier one, until you lift what you never could before. Whatever you achieved in the past came the same way, through steady repetition. For example: "I passed my driving test after failing twice. I can learn to guard my tongue the same way, one day at a time."

5. When you slip after a few good days, what do you usually tell yourself? What would it look like to simply turn back to Allah and start again?

> Slips are expected: on the 30-day sheet one attempt may fail on day nine and the next on day 18 before the third goes all the way. Adam forgot and turned back to Allah, while Iblis refused to admit he was wrong. Shaytan wants you to say "I'm hopeless", yet despairing of Allah's mercy is itself a major sin, and tawbah (repentance) simply means turning back. For example: "I usually tell myself I will never change. Instead I could ask Allah's forgiveness and start again tomorrow."

6. Who in your life is the hardest to leave in a better state, and what one small thing could you do for them this week?

> Good character means leaving everyone you meet in a better state than you found them, through appreciation, patience, or something as simple as letting a driver out in traffic. The Prophet ﷺ told Abu Dharr it is one of two qualities that are light to carry and heavy on the scales. For example: "My teenage son, as we often clash. This week I will thank him for something I usually take for granted and stay patient instead of reacting."

7. How might your day feel different if you remembered, every hour, that Allah is with you, seeing and hearing you?

> The session's second habit is silence with remembrance: remembering that Allah is with you, sees you and hears you, as He told Musa and Harun. A silent, vibrating alarm every hour is the reminder to pause and talk to Allah about what you are doing, like asking Ar-Razzaq (the Provider) to make a difficult spreadsheet easy. For example: "I would feel less alone and less stressed at work, and I would be more careful about what I say and look at."

My action plan

- [ ] I will set an hourly silent alarm today to remember that Allah is with me, sees me and hears me.
- [ ] I will try to leave every person I meet in a better state than I found them.
- [ ] I will track both habits for 30 days and complete at least the first seven before the next session.
- [ ] If I miss a day, I will not give up; I will turn back to Allah and keep going.
- [ ] I will work on one quality at a time, starting with the tongue after this sheet.
- [ ] I will set my aspirations high and remember that even my intention is rewarded.